

# SLO Triage Pack — 8 Statements

**Day 4 • Activity 1 handout.** Eight SLO statements drawn from real (anonymized) systems. Triage each: is it clean, or does it fail one of the common checks? Then rewrite the five worst so they pass **percentile + window + defense**.

## The common failure modes

| FAILURE MODE                   | WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE                                           |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| No measurement window          | A target with no period — "always"? "best case"?             |
| No percentile (or "average")   | Averages hide bimodal distributions                          |
| No defense                     | A number with no rationale for <i>why that number</i>        |
| Aspirational beyond capability | A target the team's staffing/infra can't sustain             |
| Mismatched to user threshold   | A target far looser or tighter than the user actually needs  |
| Confusion with SLA             | A <i>contractual</i> commitment stated as an internal target |

## The 8 statements

1. `p95 < 400ms`
2. `Average response time < 500ms`
3. `99.9% availability`
4. `99.99% availability` (for a 2-engineer feature on shared infra)
5. `p95 < 5s` (for a typing-feedback feature)
6. `We commit to 99.99% availability`
7. `p99 ≤ 800ms, 99.9% of the time over 30 days`
8. `Error rate under 1% during business hours, measured on the checkout endpoint`

## Your protocol

1. **Triage all 8** (15 min). Label each with its failure mode(s), or mark "**clean**" if it passes.
2. **Rewrite the 5 worst** (15 min) so each passes all three checks: **percentile + window + defense**.
3. **Identify the one with the most subtle failure** (5 min) — discuss in the readout.

## The three checks a clean SLO passes

- **Percentile** — p95 / p99, *not* "average."
- **Window** — "over 30 days," *not* "always" / unstated.
- **Defense** — a stated reason tied to user behavior or platform precedent, *not* a bare number.

Readout (60 sec)

"The most subtle failure was [X] because [why]. Our cleanest rewrite was [example]."

Triage grid

| # | STATEMENT | FAILURE MODE(S) / "CLEAN" | REWRITE (IF AMONG WORST 5) |
|---|-----------|---------------------------|----------------------------|
| 1 |           |                           |                            |
| 2 |           |                           |                            |
| 3 |           |                           |                            |
| 4 |           |                           |                            |
| 5 |           |                           |                            |
| 6 |           |                           |                            |
| 7 |           |                           |                            |
| 8 |           |                           |                            |